

RDF/OWL Task Group Report - 2013-10-21

An important activity of the RDF task group during 2013 was the completion of the Darwin Core RDF Guide. The guide was written by several task group members in conjunction with the Darwin Core Task Group, represented by John Wiecezorek. Following a period of review by the full task group and subsequent revisions, there was a consensus to recommend that the guide be approved as an addition to the Darwin Core standard. The guide is now waiting for clarification from the Executive Committee as to the next steps required to move the proposal forward.

Several RDF task group members collaborated with the Vocabulary Management Group (VoMaG) to assist in the creation of its report and recommendations. That report has been completed and released. The VoMaG group will probably provide details on this.

Task group members have also taken a leadership role in planning a Documenting Darwin Core session at the TDWG Conference which will attempt to clarify several aspects of Darwin Core, including lack of clarity about the meaning of `dwc:basisOfRecord`, the DwC Type Vocabulary, and Occurrence. It will also try to make progress toward closing several longstanding open DwC proposals - in particular the proposal to add `Organism` and `CollectionObject` classes.

Task group members have also been active in planning a Semantics of Biodiversity Symposium at the TDWG Conference. The symposium includes an educational primer session as well as three sessions to highlight the ways that semantic technology has been used to address questions of interest to the biodiversity informatics community.

Goals for the Next Year

We have identified possible changes to Darwin Core that would make the standard more compatible with the semantic web, without breaking current implementations. Goals for the coming year include building consensus around these changes, formally proposing them, and shepherding them through the review process. The Documenting Darwin Core workshop will be an early opportunity to pursue the first two of these goals.

Once this is done, the Darwin Core RDF Guide may have to be revised to reflect the changes to Darwin Core, and this revision is another goal for the group.

Respectfully submitted,
Steve Baskauf and Joel Sachs, co-conveners